

STAGE SEVEN • HARD SKILLS

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR NOTES / SCRIPT

Suggested language for openings, transitions, and prompting discussion

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Notes / Script

Stage Seven • Hard Skills

HOW TO USE THIS SCRIPT

This document is written for a first-time or less confident facilitator who wants actual suggested language, not just a topic list. Everything in quotes is meant to be read close to verbatim, or adapted lightly into your own voice.

Given this stage's thirteen sub-sessions, Part 1 covers all thirteen openings in a compact form. Parts 2 through 4 focus on the specific moments most worth a facilitator's deliberate attention across a stage this technical and this long — transitions that maintain narrative coherence across so many individual FIRSTS, discussion prompts for moments of technical frustration or social awkwardness, and specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get stuck.

Part 1 — Sub-Session Openings

Opening Sub-Session 1A

“Welcome to Stage Seven — Hard Skills, the largest stage in this entire program. Ninety FIRSTS across six sections, split into thirteen sub-sessions like this one. We're starting with Data & Analysis, since spreadsheet and data fluency underpins a huge amount of entry-level work.”

“A lot of today is genuinely hands-on — you'll be working directly in a spreadsheet, not just discussing concepts. Have your laptop ready and, if you have one, a real messy dataset from school or work to use throughout this section.”

Opening Sub-Session 1B

“We're picking up Data & Analysis where we left off. You should have your dataset from 1A ready to continue working with — today builds directly on it rather than starting fresh.”

Opening Sub-Session 2A

“Today shifts from numbers to words — Documents & Written Communication. The core theme across this whole section is clarity: writing that's genuinely easy for someone else to follow, not writing that sounds impressive.”

Opening Sub-Session 2B

“We're continuing Documents & Written Communication. Today leans more into writing for other people specifically — documentation, proposals, team processes — building on the foundational writing skills from 2A.”

Opening Sub-Session 3A

“Welcome to Planning & Project Management, the largest section in this stage at eighteen FIRSTS, split across three sub-sessions. Today is about foundations: plans, agendas, budgets, risk, and tracking.”

“Identify a real project you can plan and eventually execute across all three of these sub-sessions — continuity here will make the later execution work much more meaningful.”

Opening Sub-Session 3B

“We're moving from planning into execution skills today: process improvement, completing a mini project, checklists, and workflow optimization. Bring your project plan from 3A.”

Opening Sub-Session 3C

“This is our final sub-session on Planning & Project Management — full execution and closure. By the end of today, you'll have taken a real plan all the way through to a documented close.”

Opening Sub-Session 4A

“Today we move into Visual & Presentation Tools. The theme across this whole section: visuals should make things clearer, not just look more impressive.”

Opening Sub-Session 4B

“We're continuing Visual & Presentation Tools, moving into audience-specific work: presenting to non-experts, building a portfolio, and sharing work publicly. Two of today's exercises put you in front of a real or simulated outside audience.”

Opening Sub-Session 5A

"Today is Digital Tools & Systems — the practical infrastructure underneath everything else in this stage. Bring a laptop with access to at least one collaboration tool."

Opening Sub-Session 5B

"We're continuing Digital Tools & Systems with a more advanced focus: automation, integration, and combining multiple tools into one real project."

Opening Sub-Session 6A

"Welcome to Collaboration & Reflection, the closing section of this entire stage. Today is less about building something new and more about applying what you've built, out loud, with other people, and reflecting honestly on it."

Opening Sub-Session 6B (Stage Close)

"This is our final sub-session, not just of this section but of the entire ninety-FIRST stage. Bring every worksheet and reflection you've completed across the last twelve sub-sessions — today asks you to look back across all of it."

Part 2 — Transitions

Given the sheer number of individual FIRSTS in this stage, transitions matter more here than almost anywhere else in the program — without them, ninety FIRSTS can start to feel like an undifferentiated checklist.

K1 → K2

“You've got basic spreadsheet fluency. Now let's put it to work on something more open-ended: pulling a genuine takeaway out of raw numbers.”

1A → 1B

“This morning was about individual technical skills — formulas, surveys, statistics. This afternoon shifts toward applying those skills to genuinely messy, real-world data and communicating what you find.”

K33 → K36

“Now that you can evaluate a source's credibility, let's build something reusable — a template that saves you from rebuilding the same document structure every time.”

2A → 2B

“You've built strong individual writing skills. Now we shift toward writing specifically for other people — documentation, templates, and proposals meant for someone else to actually use.”

K12 → K23

“You've identified real risks. A plan and a risk list are only useful if you keep tracking against them — that's what we build next.”

3A → 3B

“Your plan is built. Today is about actually executing against it — completing something small first, before we take on full multi-step execution in the next sub-session.”

3B → 3C

“You've practiced individual execution skills. This final sub-session on planning asks you to run the full arc — plan through genuine closure — on one real project.”

K31 → K32

“You just built a chart for numeric data. A workflow diagram applies the same principle, visual clarity, to a process instead of a dataset.”

4A → 4B

“You've built strong visual materials. Now let's test them: presenting to a real non-expert audience, and putting your best work in front of the world through a portfolio.”

K41 → K47

“Your files are organized. Automation is the next logical step — letting a tool handle a task you'd otherwise do manually, every time, by hand.”

5A → 5B

“You've built solid tool foundations. Today goes further: automating tasks, integrating tools together, and combining several into one real project.”

K19 → K21

“You just practiced giving feedback on someone else's work. Public speaking asks a different but related question: how do you receive and respond to feedback on your own delivery, live?”

6A → 6B

"Today closes out the entire stage. Everything from the last twelve sub-sessions — data, writing, planning, visuals, tools — comes together in one honest, final self-assessment and development plan."

Part 3 — Prompting Discussion in the Moment

Five situations that come up often in a long, technical stage like this one.

A participant feels overwhelmed by the sheer number of FIRSTS in this stage

"This is genuinely the biggest stage in the program — that's true, not just a feeling. You don't need to master everything at once; by the end, K56 and K60 will help you identify exactly where to focus going forward."

Someone's technical skill level varies significantly from the rest of the group

"That's completely normal in a stage this broad — no one is equally strong across data, writing, visuals, and tools. Focus on your own honest starting point rather than comparing to the room."

A group brainstorm or negotiation role-play stalls or feels awkward

"Awkward is a completely normal part of practicing something new out loud. Let's push through this round, and we'll debrief what specifically felt hard afterward."

Someone resists a peer teaching or feedback exercise, feeling unqualified

"You don't have to be an expert to teach something — you just need to be one step ahead of your partner on this specific skill. That's exactly where most of us are on most things."

Technical troubleshooting (K54) genuinely isn't working during the session

"This is actually a live example of the exact skill we're practicing — let's slow down and change exactly one thing at a time rather than trying multiple fixes at once."

Part 4 — Tricky Moments by FIRST

Five specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get stuck, frustrated, or self-conscious.

FIRST K53

Data Cleaning Exercise

FACILITATOR NOTE

Real messy data can be genuinely frustrating to work with, especially under time pressure. Normalize that this frustration is itself part of the real skill — professional data work is rarely clean, and tolerance for that mess is part of what's being built here.

FIRST K74

Task Delegation Exercise

FACILITATOR NOTE

Some participants, especially those newer to any leadership experience, may feel uncomfortable “assigning” work to a peer even in a role-play. Frame it explicitly as practice, not a real hierarchy, to lower the social awkwardness.

FIRST K51

Technical Presentation to Non-Experts

FACILITATOR NOTE

This can be genuinely humbling if a non-expert audience doesn't understand something the presenter assumed was obvious. Frame this explicitly as the actual point of the exercise — catching that gap now is far better than in a real high-stakes presentation.

FIRST K85

Reflection on Learning Gaps

FACILITATOR NOTE

After eighty-plus FIRSTS, some participants will feel discouraged focusing on what's still difficult rather than what's improved. Explicitly balance this: acknowledge genuine growth first, then ask for one honest gap, not an exhaustive list.

FIRST K86

Mock Client/Instructor Feedback Implementation

FACILITATOR NOTE

As the closing exercise of the entire stage, some participants may feel additional pressure here. Keep the stakes genuinely low — this is about practicing the skill of receiving and acting on feedback, not about producing a perfect final result.